

Radeon 6700?

Chinese site claims to have leaked details about AMD's upcoming graphics card

Google Video Chat

Google tweaks its video chat to provide improved image quality

Reinforcements have arrived...

A look at the advancements in HD media players in the last few months

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Watching movies is a great pass-time activity, but broadcasted television does not interest the audience as much, especially with the choice of channels. Many people prefer watching movies over TV shows on their large LCD and Plasma TVs. Blu-ray content looks like the only way out.

This is where HD media players come in. They're affordable media playback devices which can playback high-definition movies from a connected storage drive smoothly. HTPCs and Blu-ray players are either expensive or just plain complicated to set up, so a lot of people probably don't bother with one.

We tested HD media players in May this year, and there were some clear winners. Since then, there have been many new contenders. New features have

been added or have become the norm for these players. We've tested some of these new players over the last couple of months. We tested them to see if there were any new features and performance benefits that are worth your money. Here's what we thought.

Xtreamer Pro

The Xtreamer was one of our favorite HD players in the last test. When you go looking for the Xtreamer Pro on the web, you find a fancy web site that resembles a game. It looks like they're pushing the new product even more.

The new player is somewhat taller and wider than the older Xtreamer. The old one could only accommodate a 2.5-inch internal hard drive, which then seemed like a neat feature. This new one can hold two 3.5-inch drives easily. This makes the product slightly bulkier than most of the media players in the market today.

The chassis is well built. A metal front panel instead of the plastic one would have made it look even more attractive. There is a USB port and an eSATA port in line with the status LEDs at the front. The rear end of the product has an additional USB2.0 port to connect external drives and one to connect the player to a PC. The player has HDMI, and Composite but no Component. For ideal resolutions, you absolutely need a display supporting HDMI.

Bootup time is somewhat long at 19 seconds. The interface has changed a little bit. The use of background wallpapers is new, but not something everyone will like. Content is sorted well. Navigating the menus is a breeze. The use of space on the remote is good.

One of the features is the NAS mode which allows other devices on the network to access drives connected to the player. Live internet streaming, RSS feeds support, Picasa and

Youtube are some of the other features available. Streaming performance is good with both wired and wireless connections. Video quality is good, and we experienced absolutely no lag while trying playback of all formats. Format support is still excellent when compared to most of the other players.

Costing ₹13,500 for just the player and an additional ₹1,000 for the USB Wi-Fi adapter, it's definitely much more expensive than the older Xtreamer player. At ₹8,990, the older Xtreamer product gives you most of the feature.



Xtreamer Pro